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2009: YEAR OF THE POPCORN

Siddharth Parwatay

As the New Year just about indolently commences, it's the perfect time to plan out your entertainment calendar with the biggest blockbuster flicks of 2009. Big budget seemed to be the trend in 2008 with hits such as *Iron Man*, *Indiana Jones*, *The Dark Knight* and *Hancock* dominating the box office. And by the looks of it, a spill over of this trend into 2009 is on the cards. You can probably say bye-bye to chick flicks (yeah, right! - ed) as 2009 promises to be quite a testosterone powered, guy-friendly year in

movies with the return of legendary film makers such as Martin Scorsese, Tarantino, and James Cameron with multiple macho offerings. Hollywood has also realised the audience's penchant for dark graphic novel adaptations this year. But don't be shell-shocked; for those of you who want some variety in your entertainment platter, there are a fair number of fun comedies and remakes too. Not to leave anyone out, pseudo-intellectuals can also rejoice; you have a smattering of those oh-so-obscure, controversial, unpronounceable ones that make for good conversation. So, without further ado here's a first look of a different kind...

Watchmen

Although this list is not in any particular order, this one just had to be at the top. That's because we at Digit haven't been this excited about a movie since, err *Ben Hur*; no wait *Dark Knight*! "Why", you ask? Well what's not to

get excited about? It's an adaptation of one of the world's most influential graphic novels, it's superlative film noir, and the plot revolves around a group of washed-up superheroes who reunite after a mysterious and possibly apocalyptic threat emerges. What's more, it's directed by Zack Snyder, so we can expect some of the same magic we saw in *300* (you mean rubbish? - ed). Apart from the movie itself, there is a whole lot of hullabaloo about the film living up to the comic book. Us geeks can be an unforgiving lot.

So while there are those who believe that a motion picture based on the Alan Moore/Dave Gibbons cult classic just cannot do justice to the comic, others are breath-

Bring out the popcorn, hunker down on your favourite couch—2009 is here with movies aplenty

ing a sigh of relief that at least Zack Snyder is the one destined to direct it. Destined because several others including Darren Aronofsky and Paul Greengrass, have had to abandon the project at the drawing board stage.

So what can movie goers expect? A dark, gritty, intense, complex, action-packed experience that will definitely have your pulse up a few notches and give you a look into the world of the flawed superhero. It's really more of a murder mystery with spectacular visuals and superhero ultra-violent action thrown in for good measure. There's supposed to be a rather sexually explicit scene too. The film brings out how bizarre and screwy people would be if they put on masks and went about beating up baddies. You'll either be lost or spell-bound by the richness of the characters, their philosophical debates, and their origin stories. There are several to pick your favourite from too; the good-guy Nite Owl, the sexy Silk Spectre, the always intelligent Ozymandias, the omnipotent Dr. Manhattan and the one who starts it all — Rorschach. What is important to note here is that even if you are not a fanboy, you'll have extreme reactions about the movie. You'll either love it or downright hate it.

Inglourious Basterds

Whats big about this one? Three reasons – Tarantino, Tarantino and Quentin Tarantino. There's also the star cast, comprising Brad Pitt, Mike Myers and Diane Kruger, but still the driving force behind all the hype is the famous director's solo return to film after wrapping up *Kill Bill* way back in 2004. But wait a minute, did it say Mike Myres? There's something funny going on here; we came across reports that the film originally was to feature an appearance by Adam Sandler. What's with the funny men? In any case, there's nothing funny about the plot of *Inglourious Basterds*. It follows a bunch of WWII-era Jewish-American soldiers as they embark on a campaign of terror by tracking down and brutally terminating Nazi commanders. The film is Tarantino's first attempt at a period film, but going by initial reports it's got his trademark stamp of controversy and path-breaking cinema all over it.

What can film buffs expect? Well the ladies can get some eye candy courtesy pretty-boy Brad Pitt. As for you guys, if you loved gritty war-time films depicting a few "band of brothers" on a mission (read *Saving Private Ryan*), you will surely appreciate this one. Mark a slot around August.

Shutter Island

This film starring Leonardo DiCaprio and Ben Kingsley is based on the novel by Dennis Lehane that follows a pair of U.S. Marshalls as they investigate the disappearance of a criminally insane patient. The book follows Marshalls Teddy Daniels and Chuck Aule's (Dicaprio and Mark Ruffalo) visit to Shutter Island. While they are there to investigate the apparent disappearance or possible escape of a female inmate, they discover a sinister plot of illegal experiments being conducted on the patients under the guise of the cold war. (The book is set in the 1950s). To complicate matters further, a hurricane is approaching. We hope that the movie will be able to capture the book's suspense and the mind-numbing twist at the end.

With this one it looks like Martin Scorsese wants to bank on the success he got from having Leonardo star in his previous films, such as *The Departed* and *Gangs of New York*. Apart from the star cast however, Scorsese's winning streak should be more than enough for you to go and have a look at this one. And c'mon, who didn't like *Taxi Driver* and *Good Fellas*?

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